GCSE English misconception bank

Language and literature. The mistakes are about method. If your set text is different, swap the example and keep the mistake.

These are hinge questions for mistakes that come up again and again at GCSE. The topics are the ones pupils meet on AQA and Edexcel courses. They are not past papers, and they are not a mark scheme. Named texts, case studies and optional units differ by school. Swap the example. Keep the mistake.

Each wrong answer is a reason to reteach. The shaded box is for you. Cover it if the page is on the board.

35 hinges.

LANGUAGE ANALYSIS · 1

A pupil writes: “The writer uses a metaphor, so it is effective.” What is missing?

A. What those words make the reader think or feel.
B. Nothing. Naming the technique is the whole job.
C. A second metaphor. One is never enough, whatever it does.
D. The writer’s date of birth.

Correct: A.

B. A label was treated as analysis.

C. A quota of features was invented.

D. Biography was demanded in place of an effect.

Reteach: Name the method, quote a few of the words, and say what those words do. A label on its own is not a point about the text.

LANGUAGE ANALYSIS · 2

“The classroom was a zoo.” This is

A. a metaphor. It says the classroom is a zoo, with no “like” or “as”.
B. a simile, because any comparison is a simile.
C. a fact, so there is nothing to say about the words.
D. onomatopoeia.

Correct: A.

B. The two names were collapsed. A simile compares with “like” or “as”.

C. An image was read as a literal claim.

D. A sound technique was named for a comparison.

Reteach: A simile uses “like” or “as”. A metaphor states one thing as the other. Then say what the comparison makes the classroom seem like. The name alone is not the point.

WRITER'S PURPOSE · 3

"The writer uses this image because she felt lonely that morning." What is the problem?

A. We can write about the effect of the words. We cannot know a private feeling the text does not show.
B. Nothing. An image is proof of what the writer felt that day.
C. Writers do not choose words, so purpose cannot be discussed.
D. The only legal comment is about spelling.

Correct: A.

B. The writing was treated as a diary of the writer's mood.

C. Choice was denied. You can still write about what the words do.

D. Analysis was reduced to proofreading.

Reteach: Write the effect from the text: what the choice makes a reader notice. Do not invent a mood for the writer's morning unless a source actually shows it.

USING QUOTATIONS · 4

Which use of a quotation is doing some work?

A. The room was "cold as a grave", so the house feels dead, not just chilly.
B. "Cold as a grave."
C. The writer uses language to describe the room.
D. A quotation should be the whole paragraph, copied out.

Correct: A.

B. The quotation was left on its own, with no point attached.

C. No words from the text were used, and no effect was named.

D. Length was treated as the virtue. A short embedded quote is enough.

Reteach: Bed the quotation into your sentence, then say what those words do. A quote with no comment is not an answer.

LANGUAGE AND STRUCTURE · 5

A text opens on a whole city and ends on one face. That shift is

A. structure: the order of the text, and where it makes you look.
B. a language feature, because every choice a writer makes is "language".
C. a simile.
D. impossible to write about, because it is not a metaphor.

Correct: A.

B. Structure was folded into language, so the zoom had nowhere to go.

C. A structural move was given the name of a comparison.

D. Analysis was limited to named images.

Reteach: Language is the words and images. Structure is the order, the shifts, the openings and endings. A zoom from the wide view to one face is structure.

LANGUAGE ANALYSIS · 6

“There are short sentences, so it is tense.” What does this still need?

A. One of those sentences, and a reason it feels tense here.
B. Nothing. Short sentences always create tension, in any text.
C. A count of the commas on the page.
D. A statement that long sentences can never be tense.

Correct: A.

B. A rule of thumb was treated as automatic.

C. A tally was substituted for an effect.

D. The opposite technique was banned. Long sentences can be tense too.

Reteach: Quote one short sentence and say what it does in this passage. Short can feel abrupt. It does not always mean tension, and a long sentence can be tense as well.

COMPARISON · 7

A question asks you to compare two texts. A useful answer

A. moves between them and compares the methods, not one essay and then another.
B. writes everything about the first text, then everything about the second, with no link.
C. mentions only the text the pupil prefers.
D. compares the page numbers.

Correct: A.

B. Two separate essays were placed next to each other and called a comparison.

C. Comparison needs both.

D. A surface detail replaced the methods.

Reteach: Use words that actually compare: both, whereas, unlike. When the point is shared, put the two texts in the same paragraph.

SUMMARY · 8

A summary of a text should

A. select the relevant points and say them briefly, in your own words.
B. copy out the sentences that look important.
C. give an opinion of the writer’s childhood.
D. analyse metaphors, and ignore what the text is telling you.

Correct: A.

B. The text was transcribed. That is not a summary.

C. Biography replaced the information in the text.

D. A language essay was written in place of a summary. They are different jobs.

Reteach: A summary picks out what the question asks for and condenses it. Copying lines is not selecting. Save the close language work for the language question.

INFERENCE · 9

The narrator locks the door, then goes back and locks it again. A pupil writes: “The character locks the door.” What is weak?

A. It only repeats the text. An inference would say what the second check suggests, such as not feeling safe.
B. Nothing. The best inference repeats the line word for word.
C. You must not mention the door.
D. Inference means copying a whole page.

Correct: A.

B. Retrieval was labelled as inference.

C. The evidence was banned. The inference still has to come from it.

D. Length was confused with reading between the lines.

Reteach: “Locks the door” is retrieval. “Does not feel safe” is an inference, and it still needs the repeated check as evidence. Go one step past the words, and no further than they will support.

TONE · 10

After a groan, a character says, “Oh, brilliant. Another test.” A pupil writes that the character is pleased. What went wrong?

A. The tone was missed. In that context the line is sarcastic, not sincere.
B. Nothing. A character always means the dictionary sense of the words.
C. Sarcasm is a spelling mistake.
D. You can only detect tone in a poem.

Correct: A.

B. Tone and context were ignored.

C. A matter of tone was reclassified as a slip of the pen.

D. Prose and drama were excluded. Tone is in all of them.

Reteach: Read the line with what is around it. Praise that follows a groan is often the opposite of praise. Quote the clue that shows the tone.

NARRATIVE WRITING · 11

A story ends: “Then I woke up and it was all a dream.” Why is that a weak default ending?

A. It deletes the problem of the story instead of following it through.
B. It is the most satisfying ending, and it should be used whenever you are stuck.
C. Stories are not allowed to end.
D. A dream is a punctuation mark.

Correct: A.

B. A way out of the plot was treated as a resolution.

C. The objection was exaggerated. The problem is this kind of ending, not ending.

D. Form was confused with a trick of the plot.

Reteach: The reader has been asked to care about a problem. Waking up cancels it. End on a consequence, a choice, or an image that follows from what happened.

DESCRIPTIVE WRITING · 12

“The dark, scary, creepy, horrible wood was bad.” What is the weakness?

A. The adjectives all mean the same thing, and nothing is shown.
B. Nothing. More adjectives always make a description better.
C. It contains a verb, and description must not.
D. The sentence is too short to be judged.

Correct: A.

B. Quantity of adjectives was treated as quality.

C. Verbs were banned. A precise verb often does the work.

D. Length was treated as the standard.

Reteach: Choose one detail a reader can see or hear. “The branch tapped the window” does more than four words that all mean frightening.

LETTER WRITING · 13

A letter to a headteacher begins: “In this essay I will argue that homework is bad.” What is off?

A. It is an essay opening. A letter needs the reader, the reason for writing, and a fitting tone.
B. Nothing. A letter and an essay are the same form.
C. A letter must not give any reasons.
D. Only the sign-off matters. The opening can be anything.

Correct: A.

B. Audience and layout were ignored.

C. Argument was banned. A letter can argue. It has to sound like a letter.

D. The relationship with the reader starts in the first line.

Reteach: Name the person and why you are writing, in the opening. Keep a tone that person would actually receive. An essay voice addressed to nobody drops the form.

SPEECH WRITING · 14

A speech begins: “This essay is about litter.” What would make it a speech?

A. Address the people in the room, and write lines that can be said to them.
B. Nothing needs to change. A speech is an essay read aloud.
C. Take out every opinion.
D. Add the headings you would use in a report.

Correct: A.

B. The audience was left out.

C. A speech without a view has no reason to be given.

D. A report’s layout was imported into a speech.

Reteach: A speech knows who is listening. Use “you”, give them a reason to stay with you, and write a line you could say out loud. Headings belong to a report.

PARAGRAPHING · 15

A whole story is written as one paragraph. What is the cost?

A. Shifts of time, place, speaker or focus are hidden. A new paragraph is how you mark them.
B. Nothing. Paragraphs are decoration.
C. Every sentence must be its own paragraph, so one block is the only other option.
D. Paragraphs are only used in poetry.

Correct: A.

B. Paragraphs were treated as optional styling.

C. The choice was made all-or-nothing. Paragraph at the change, not at every full stop.

D. Prose was excluded. Paragraphs organise prose.

Reteach: Start a new paragraph when something changes: time, place, topic, or speaker. One block makes the shape of the piece impossible to see.

APOSTROPHES · 16

Which sentence is standard English?

A. The dog wagged its tail.
B. The dog wagged it’s tail.
C. The dog wagged its’ tail.
D. The dog wagged its’s tail.

Correct: A.

B. It’s was used for possession. It’s means “it is” or “it has”.

C. An apostrophe was added to the possessive “its”, which does not take one.

D. A second possessive ending was bolted on.

Reteach: If you can swap in “it is”, write it’s. The possessive, as in “its tail”, has no apostrophe.

APOSTROPHES · 17

Which shows that the books belong to one pupil?

A. the pupil’s books
B. the pupils books
C. the pupils’ books
D. the pupil books’

Correct: A.

B. The apostrophe was left out, so the ownership is not marked.

C. That apostrophe is for more than one pupil.

D. The apostrophe was put on the thing owned, not on the owner.

Reteach: One owner: pupil’s. More than one pupil: pupils’. No apostrophe does not show ownership. Put the apostrophe on the owner.

SENTENCES · 18

What is wrong with “The bell rang, everyone ran”?

A. Two sentences have been joined with only a comma.
B. Nothing. A comma is enough to join two sentences that could stand alone.
C. The comma should be an apostrophe.
D. A comma must never be used.

Correct: A.

B. A comma splice was accepted as correct.

C. Two different punctuation jobs were swapped.

D. The objection was over-widened. Commas are fine. They cannot hold two full sentences on their own.

Reteach: Each half can stand as its own sentence. Use a full stop, or a joining word such as “and” or “so”. A comma alone cannot do that job.

STANDARD ENGLISH · 19

Which is standard English?

A. I could have done it.
B. I could of done it.
C. I could has done it.
D. I could of have done it.

Correct: A.

B. “Could’ve” was heard as “could of”. “Of” is not a verb.

C. The verb after “could” was put in the wrong form.

D. Both the mishearing and the real verb were kept.

Reteach: The verb is have. Could’ve is the short form of could have. It is not could of.

LITERATURE: CHARACTER · 20

A pupil writes: “Macbeth was a real man, so Shakespeare had no choices.” What is off?

A. The Macbeth of the play is a construct. Shakespeare chooses what he does and when.
B. Nothing. A character and a historical person are the same kind of evidence.
C. You may not write about what Macbeth does.
D. The play is a diary Macbeth wrote.

Correct: A.

B. The play was treated as a camera on a life.

C. The actions were banned. They are exactly what you write about, as choices in the play.

D. The form was misnamed. It is a play, shaped by a writer.

Reteach: There was a historical Macbeth. The play is not a record of him. Write about the character as Shakespeare builds him: what he is given to say and do, and what that is for.

LITERATURE: CONTEXT · 21

“Shakespeare was Jacobean, so Macbeth is about witches.” What is weak?

A. The context never meets a moment in the play. It is stuck on the front.
B. Nothing. Naming the period is the whole of a context point.
C. You must not mention when a play was written.
D. Witches do not appear in Macbeth.

Correct: A.

B. A date was treated as analysis.

C. Context was banned. The problem is the bolt-on, not the history.

D. The text was misremembered. The witches open the play. The weakness is the unused context.

Reteach: Use context on a scene. If you mention James and the fear of witchcraft, show where the play uses that fear, such as the opening. A date on its own does no work.

LITERATURE: THEME · 22

A pupil says the theme of Macbeth is “witches”. What is the better way to put it?

A. Witches are part of the story. A theme is an idea the play keeps returning to, such as ambition or guilt.
B. “Witches” is the theme, because a theme is the main object in the plot.
C. A theme is the name of the author.
D. Themes are only found in poems.

Correct: A.

B. A topic was named as a theme.

C. Terminology was emptied out.

D. Drama was excluded. Plays have themes.

Reteach: A topic is what appears: a crown, a ghost, witches. A theme is the idea, such as ambition, guilt or power. Write the idea, not the prop.

LITERATURE: DRAMA · 23

Macbeth is alone on stage and speaks his thoughts. That speech is

A. a soliloquy.
B. an aside, which is the same thing as a soliloquy.
C. a dialogue with Banquo.
D. a stage direction.

Correct: A.

B. An aside is a short line past the other characters, who are still there. A soliloquy is spoken alone.

C. Dialogue needs another speaker. He is alone.

D. A speech was confused with an instruction to the actors.

Reteach: Soliloquy: the character is alone, thinking aloud. Aside: a short remark the other characters are not meant to hear. Dialogue: characters speaking to each other.

LITERATURE: EVIDENCE · 24

A pupil uses “Fair is foul, and foul is fair” for every point in a Macbeth essay. What is the problem?

A. One line cannot carry five different ideas. The quotation has to fit the point.
B. Nothing. One quotation is all an essay needs.
C. You should not quote the play.
D. Only the first line of a play may be quoted.

Correct: A.

B. A single line was treated as universal evidence.

C. Evidence was banned. The problem is the mismatch, not the quoting.

D. A rule was invented. The line is usable when the point is about it.

Reteach: The witches’ line is about appearance and reality. It will not prove a point about sleep, or about Lady Macbeth, unless you show a real link. Usually the point needs its own line.

LITERATURE: METHOD · 25

“Shakespeare uses this to show that Macbeth is guilty.” What is missing?

A. The method: which words, action or structure do the showing.
B. Nothing. “To show” is a method.
C. A statement that Macbeth is not a character.
D. The price of a ticket in 1606.

Correct: A.

B. A purpose-phrase was mistaken for an analysis of how.

C. The character was removed. You write about him as a construct, you do not deny he is one.

D. An unrelated fact was demanded instead of the method.

Reteach: Add the how. “The short questions after the dagger speech show a mind that cannot settle” names a method. “To show” on its own is a purpose with no evidence.

MACBETH · 26

Before Macbeth has murdered Duncan, the Captain in Act 1 Scene 2 describes him as

A. a brave, loyal thane, fighting for Duncan.
B. already the murderer of the king.
C. a servant in the kitchen, with no reputation in battle.
D. someone the Captain has never heard of.

Correct: A.

B. The fall was erased. The murder has not happened yet.

C. The Captain’s report was inverted.

D. The whole of the report was denied. The scene exists to build his reputation.

Reteach: The Captain calls him brave and reports his service to Duncan. The play gives him a loyal reputation before the murder. Write the fall. Do not start him as a villain.

A CHRISTMAS CAROL · 27

A pupil says Scrooge changes only because the ghosts frighten him. What else does the novella give him?

A. Visions of consequence: his past, people suffering now, and a future in which he is unmourned.
B. Nothing else. Fear of a ghost is the whole of the change.
C. A pay rise from Marley.
D. Proof that he was never miserly.

Correct: A.

B. The visions were left out. Fear gets his attention. What he is shown does the work.

C. The plot was rewritten. Marley is there to warn him.

D. The starting character was denied. The change matters because he begins as he does.

Reteach: Fear gets his attention. Name a vision: Tiny Tim, Ignorance and Want, or his own grave. The change is in what he is made to see, not only in being scared.

AN INSPECTOR CALLS · 28

At the end of An Inspector Calls, the Inspector is

A. left unexplained. The play does not settle whether he was a police officer.
B. revealed to be a ghost, and the play confirms it.
C. proved to be an ordinary inspector from the local station.
D. revealed to be Eric in disguise.

Correct: A.

B. An open ending was closed. Priestley does not confirm a ghost.

C. The phone calls were flattened into one answer. The play sets the two possibilities against each other.

D. A theory was stated as the plot. The text does not show this.

Reteach: Do not close a question the play leaves open. Write about why it is left open, and whether the family uses the second chance. You do not have to solve who he was.

AN INSPECTOR CALLS · 29

By the end of An Inspector Calls, Sheila and Mr Birling

A. have not learned the same lesson. Sheila accepts blame. Birling is still protecting himself.
B. change in the same way, because they heard the same story.
C. both decide the Inspector was wrong about everything, and say so in the same words.
D. swap jobs at the works.

Correct: A.

B. The family was treated as one person.

C. Sheila's shift was rubbed out.

D. The plot was invented. The difference is in what they accept, not in a new job.

Reteach: Same visit, different response. Use a line of Sheila's that Birling would not say. Do not write "the Birlings" as if they were a single reaction.

POETRY · 30

A poem uses “I”. Who is speaking?

A. A speaker, or persona. It is not automatically the poet’s own life.
B. Always the poet, with no gap between life and voice.
C. Always a character from a novel studied in class.
D. Nobody. Poems do not have a voice.

Correct: A.

B. The “I” was treated as a signature.

C. Voice was imported from a different text.

D. The speaker was denied. Voice is one of the things you can write about.

Reteach: Call them the speaker unless you have a reason to identify the poet. The voice is a choice, in the way a character is a choice.

POETRY · 31

A poem begins in pride and ends in emptiness. A pupil calls it “a happy poem”. What is missed?

A. The turn. The change of feeling is often the point.
B. Nothing. The first line fixes the mood of the whole poem.
C. Poems are not allowed to change mood.
D. Only the title counts. The ending can be ignored.

Correct: A.

B. A poem was treated as one note.

C. A ban was invented. The change is what you write about.

D. The place where poems often turn was thrown away.

Reteach: Track where the feeling shifts. Write about the turn. One mood pasted over the whole poem misses the structure.

POETRY: OZYMANDIAS · 32

In Ozymandias the statue is ruined. A pupil says the surviving stone proves the king’s power lasted. What is the better reading?

A. What is left is a wreck in empty sand. The boast has failed.
B. Any stone still standing means the king succeeded.
C. The poem describes a statue in perfect condition, so the power is intact.
D. Shelley says the king was right to boast.

Correct: A.

B. The remains were counted as a victory. They are what makes the boast look empty.

C. The text was misremembered. The statue is shattered and half sunk.

D. The irony was missed. The inscription is undercut by the scene around it.

Reteach: Put the inscription next to the scene. He tells the mighty to look on his works. The works are gone. The remains mock the boast. They do not prove it.

UNSEEN POETRY · 33

A pupil will not start an unseen poem because they do not know the poet's life. What should they do?

A. Read the poem. The words on the page are the evidence. A biography is not required.
B. Stop. An unseen poem cannot be answered without the poet's biography.
C. Invent a life for the poet, so the essay has some context.
D. Write about a poem they have already studied, and change the title.

Correct: A.

B. Missing context was treated as a bar on reading.

C. Biography was fabricated. Do not invent a life.

D. The unseen text was replaced. The words in front of them are the task.

Reteach: Unseen work comes from the page: voice, image, turn, and ending. Do not invent the poet's life, and do not refuse the question because you have not revised one.

POETIC FORM · 34

A sonnet is

A. a 14-line poem, usually with a set rhyme scheme and a turn. It is not any short poem.
B. any short poem.
C. any poem that rhymes, of any length.
D. a play divided into fourteen acts.

Correct: A.

B. Length was vaguely required, and the 14 lines were dropped.

C. Rhyme was treated as the whole definition.

D. A poetic form was redescribed as drama.

Reteach: Count the lines. Fourteen, usually in a set pattern, often with a turn near the end. Shakespearean and Petrarchan sonnets are shaped differently. If you name the form, say what it lets the poet do.

COMPARING POEMS · 35

A pupil compares two poems only by what they are about. What is left out?

A. How they are written: image, form, voice, and where each one turns.
B. Nothing. Comparison means matching the topics and stopping.
C. Any need to mention either poem.
D. Spelling, which is the whole of a comparison.

Correct: A.

B. Method was left out of a literature comparison.

C. The texts were removed. You still write about both.

D. A writing target replaced the literary one.

Reteach: Same idea, different method, is a comparison. If both poems are about power, say how each one shows it. Topic alone leaves the writer out.

Run one hinge in two minutes

The questions in this bank are multiple choice, so a class can show A, B, C or D on mini whiteboards. That is the fast version. You see the letter, and you reteach the line that goes with it.

If you want the sentence behind the letter, use Get It?.

1. Type the topic, or paste the question. Edit what comes back. It is your question.
2. Pupils join with the class code on a phone, a laptop, or a school device. A first name is enough. No account, and nothing to install.
3. They answer in their own words, typed or spoken. It is not multiple choice. The sentence shows the mistake more clearly than a letter does.
4. In about two minutes you get green, amber or red. The colour is guidance. It can be wrong, and you can change it.
5. Reteach the line from this bank before you move on.

Where phones are banned, do not demand a phone. Use school devices, or stay with the boards.

A first name and the answers are sent to an external AI. If school policy forbids that, do not use the tool with pupil answers. The boards still work.

Free during the beta. No card.

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